



“Remind-me” presuppositions with iterated Speech Acts¹

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¹This project started during the Spring 2025 MIT “treetops” seminar taught by Danny Fox, Sabine Iatridou and Kai von Stechow, all of whom I thank. It was recently brought to my attention that Jeanne Lecavelier (Potsdam) and Alexander Wimmer (Stuttgart) have independently produced cool work based on similar French data, and more. This work constitutes a very valuable complement to my own contribution. I thank Jeanne for bringing it up.

Introduction

“Remind-me” presuppositions (Sauerland, 2009; Sauerland & Yatsushiro, 2017)

- Consider the following scenario inspired by Sauerland and Yatsushiro (2017)–henceforth **SY17**:

Jo and Al are introduced to each other at a party and tell each other their names. As the conversation goes by, Jo realizes they forgot Al's name. Jo asks Al:

(1) What's your name #(again)?

- In this scenario, the addressee's name was contributed to the Common Ground earlier by the addressee.
- (1) then appears to presuppose that the speaker knew the name of the addressee before.
- This presupposition was dubbed “**Remind-Me**” Presupposition (**RMP**). It seems to be triggered by the particle *again* in English.

Narrowing down the content of the RMP

- Consider now this slightly different scenario, inspired again by SY17:

*At the beginning of a reception, the names of all the participants are announced. Jo doesn't know anybody but **makes no effort to listen to the announcement**. Later, Jo encounters Al, and asks them:*

(1) What's your name ??(again)?

- In this scenario, the speaker never knew the name of the addressee, but the addressee's name was contributed to the Common Ground in the past by the announcer.
- The RMP seems to imply that **the answer to the question was made Common Ground before**.²
- **How does the RMP arise, and is it attested in other languages?**

²Lecavelier and Wimmer, 2025a, 2025b, 2025c propose to replace Common Ground with Speaker Knowledge; this distinction is not a direct concern for us here.

The cross-linguistic picture

The RMP in German and Japanese

- Japanese (2) and German (3) questions can feature RMP-triggering particles (Sauerland, 2009; Sauerland & Yatsushiro, 2017).

(2) Namae-wa nan-da-**kke**?
Name-TOP what-COP-**kke**
'What's your name again? ' (RMP ✓)

(3) Wie ist **noch mal** Ihr Name?
How is **again** your name
'What's your name again? ' (RMP ✓)

- Lecavelier and Wimmer (2025a, 2025b) point out **the RMP arises in many other languages**, including Akan, Scandinavian languages, Greek and Slovenian. **Other strategies** can be recruited (*now*,³ epistemic past...see Appendix).
- Let's focus on the two languages/examples above.

³German *gleich* (mentioned by a Reviewer) may belong to that class. See Appendix for more.

The RMP with Japanese *-kke*

(2) Namae-wa nan-da-**kke**?

Name-TOP what-COP-**kke**

‘What’s your name again?’

(RMP ✓)

- In Japanese, the RMP-triggering particle does not seem to have other uses (**dedicated particle**).
- There is evidence that the particle is **syntactically high** (SY17).
- This particle thus lends itself to a **straightforward analysis**: one can assign it the RMP.

(3) Wie ist **noch mal** Ihr Name?

How is **again** your name

'What's your name again? '

(RMP ✓)

- In German, just like in English, the RMP-triggering particle normally means *again*.
- This suggests that **something about the standard meaning of *again* may trigger the RMP.**

Why *again* then?

- In declarative contexts, *again* has a repetitive meaning: it is assertorically vacuous and presupposes its prejacent was true before (see (4)).

$$(4) \quad \llbracket \text{again} \rrbracket = \llbracket \text{noch mal} \rrbracket = \lambda \langle p, e \rangle : \underline{\exists e' < e. p(e')}. p(e)$$

- SY17 show (4) can be recycled to yield the RMP, **modulo interactions with Speech Act operators**.

Past account of the RMP with
again

SY17: key Speech Act operators

- The RMP is derived from the interaction between *again* and two Speech Act operators, an **injunction to the addressee** IMP2⁴ (6) and a **Common Ground** operator CG (5).

(5) $\llbracket \text{CG} \rrbracket^{\text{spk}} = \lambda \langle Q, e \rangle. 1$ iff the speaker spk partakes in e ,
and the full answer to Q is CG in e

(6) $\llbracket \text{IMP2} \rrbracket^{\text{spk,addr}} =$
 $\lambda p. \text{it's an obligation that } \exists e. \text{addr causes } e \text{ and } p(e)$

⁴For clarity and brevity we omit the further decomposition of this operator into IMP+2.Sg+Do, where IMP is a universal modal, 2.Sg the addressee and Do a causation predicate.

- Let's first review simple questions without *again*.
- Asking a question Q corresponds to **an injunction to the addressee (IMP2) to make the answer Common Ground (CG[Q]):**⁵

(7) $\llbracket \text{IMP2 } [\text{CG}[Q]] \rrbracket^{\text{spk}, \text{addr}}$ = it's an obligation that $\exists e$. addr causes e spk partakes in e , and the full answer to Q is CG in e

⁵In SY17, this is more precisely cashed out as IMP 2.Sg Do [CG[Q]]

SY17: the *again*-sandwich

- The trick is then for *again* to scope between IMP2 and CG.

$$(4) \quad \llbracket \text{again} \rrbracket = \lambda \langle p, e \rangle : \underline{\exists e' < e. p(e')}. p(e)$$

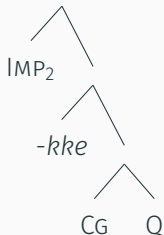


- This yields **the right at-issue meaning** (equal to IMP2 [CG[Q]]).
- Additionally, *again's* presupposition that the answer to Q was Common Ground *before*, can **project across IMP2** to yield the RMP.

$$(8) \quad \llbracket \text{IMP2} [\text{again}[\text{CG}[\text{Q}]]] \rrbracket^{\text{spk,addr}} =$$
$$\underline{\exists e' < e. \text{spk partakes in } e', \text{ and the full answer to Q is CG in } e'}.$$

it's an obligation that $\exists e. \text{addr causes } e, \text{ spk partakes in } e,$
and the full answer to Q is CG in e

- The same recipe works for the Japanese particle *-kke*.



- Why *-kke* and not a repetitive particle otherwise available in the language (e.g. *mata* or *mou ichido*)?
- SY17 propose that ***-kke* gets inserted at a spot that *mata* or *mou ichido* are not expected to reach**, since Japanese was argued to not display covert movement (Yatsushiro, 1999).

Next steps

- We'll now see that RMPs arise in French questions; but the particle (*déjà*) is **neither “dedicated” nor of the *again* type...**
- We'll then propose an analysis of the phenomenon, recycling the particle's usual semantics and proposing that it interacts with IMP2 and CG **in tricky yet predictable ways.**
- We'll lastly discuss **further data and implications** of the proposal.

French “Remind-me” questions

Déjà in declaratives: medial position

- In French, the adverb *déjà*, normally means **already** or **ever/at least once** (also noted by Lecavelier and Wimmer, 2025a, 2025b, 2025c, henceforth **LW25**).

(9) Tu as **déjà** lu Tolstoi?
You have DÉJÀ read Tolstoi?
'Have you **ever/already** read Tolstoi?' (ever more salient)

(10) Ed a **déjà** déclaré ses impôts.
Ed has DÉJÀ filed his taxes.
'Ed has filed his taxes **already/at least once** before.' (already more salient)

- The position of this particle is usually between auxiliaries and verbs, suggesting it's VP-internal.

Déjà in declaratives: final position

- *Déjà* can also appear sentence-finally, in which case the *already* reading is significantly more prominent.

- (11) Tu as lu Tolstoi **déjà**?
You have read Tolstoi DÉJÀ?
'Have you **ever/already** read Tolstoi?' (already more salient)
- (12) Ed a déclaré ses impôts **déjà**.
Ed has filed his taxes DÉJÀ.
'Ed has filed his taxes **already/at least once** before.' (already more salient)
- Whats happens when *déjà* occurs in questions?

Déjà is a RMP trigger in *wh*-questions

- In questions, sentence-final *déjà* **preferentially triggers the RMP**, (as opposed to an already-reading) regardless of *wh*-movement:⁶

(13) (Qui) tu as vu (qui) **déjà**?
Who you have seen who DÉJÀ?
'Who did you see again? ' (RMP ✓)

- Sentence-medial *déjà* **necessarily triggers the RMP** (no *already/ever* reading) **after *ex situ* *wh*-words**; see (14).

(14) Qui **déjà** tu as vu?
Who DÉJÀ you have seen DÉJÀ?
'Who did you see again? ' (RMP ✓)

- With *in situ wh*, sentence-medial *déjà* does not seem to trigger the RMP (something else happens—discussed later)

⁶Also noted by LW25.

When *déjà* does not trigger the RMP

- Unlike German *noch mal*, *déjà* cannot trigger the RMP when within VP, regardless of *wh*-movement.
- In (15), *déjà* preferentially receives an *already* interpretation.⁷

(15) (Qui) tu as **déjà** vu (qui)?
(Who) you have DÉJÀ see (who)?

‘Who have you already seen?’

(RMP ✗)

- Like German but unlike Japanese, *déjà* cannot trigger the RMP in polar questions, regardless of its position.⁸

(16) Tu as (**déjà**) vu Jo (**déjà**)?
You have DÉJÀ see Jo DÉJÀ?

‘Have you already/ever seen Jo?’

(RMP ✗)

⁷In other sentences/contexts, the *ever*-reading may arise as well.

⁸And regardless of how the polar question is formed (inversion, clefting...).

The puzzle

- Which core meaning of *déjà* is better suited to derive the RMP?
- Recall the RMP is a **presupposition** that the answer to the question was made Common Ground **before**.
- Under the *already*-reading, *déjà* at most presupposes that the prejaçant was *expected* to occur... **it's a presupposition, but definitely not the right kind!**
- Under the *ever/at least once* reading, *déjà* asserts⁹ that the prejaçant occurred before.. **that seems on the right track for the RMP, but it's not a presupposition!**¹⁰
- So, the RMP cannot arise only *via* presupposition projection in French (as it does with *noch mal/again*).

⁹The *déjà*-questions in (15-16) for instance show no projection of a putative “*done before*” presupposition of *déjà*. More supporting evidence in Appendix.

¹⁰Also noted by LW25

- We'll focus on **wh-questions** involving *déjà*.
- We propose that **the ever-meaning of *déjà* can yield the RMP**,¹¹ modulo a few (tricky) steps.
- We'll assume that *déjà*, just like *again*, ends up applying to CG[Q].
- The RMP will then arise from the interaction between *déjà*[CG[Q]] and a **second CG operator outscoping *déjà*, which will ensure that *déjà*[CG[Q]] is itself CG**.
- Put differently, the second CG will ensure that the fact the answer to Q was Common Ground in the past is a presupposed fact (that's the RMP).
- Under that view, *What's your name déjà?* ends up meaning *What's your name, **which was made CG before?***—except what's transcribed here as a supplement must be Common Ground.¹²

¹¹Intuition also entertained by LW25.

¹²Intuition also entertained by LW25.

Deriving the RMP in French

Core assumptions

- We take that *déjà* is presuppositionless and asserts *again's* presupposition:

$$(17) \quad \llbracket \text{déjà} \rrbracket = \lambda \langle p, e \rangle. \exists e' < e. p(e') = 1$$

- And we assume *déjà* is generated in VP.
- This allows us to capture the *ever* reading of *déjà* in declaratives (9-12),¹³ and questions (13-16).
- (18) shows how, if applied to CG[Q] *déjà* asserts the RMP.

$$(18) \quad \llbracket \text{déjà CG Q} \rrbracket^{\text{spk}} = \\ \lambda e. \exists e' < e. \text{spk partakes in } e', \\ \text{and the full answer to } Q \text{ is CG in } e'$$

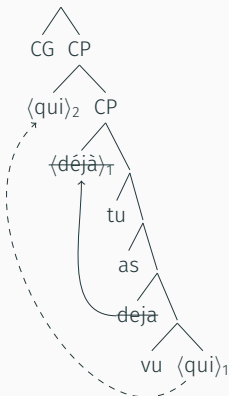
¹³In (11-12) we may assume *déjà* extraposes. Same in questions, though it'd need to land below the Speech Act operators.

The recipe

- The goal is now to derive a LF which effectively **backgrounds the assertion derived in (18)**. Here is our recipe.
 1. Overt movement of *déjà* right below Spec-CP_[+wh].
 2. (C)overt movement above CG.
 3. Insertion of a second CG operator.
 4. Movement of the lower CG[Q] constituent.
 5. Escaping IMP2 by extraposition.
- Not a simple sandwich! More like a deconstructed club sandwich.

Step 1: Overt movement to Spec-CP

- RMP-*déjà* moves *overtly* to a Spec-CP position, below CG and the Spec-CP hosting *wh*-phrases (see solid arrow in tree below).



- This overt step is in line with the word orders licensing the RMP:¹⁴

(14) High *déjà*, RMP ✓

Qui **déjà** tu as vu (‘‘qui)?
Who DÉJÀ you have seen DÉJÀ?

‘Who did you see again?’

(15) Low *déjà*, RMP ✗

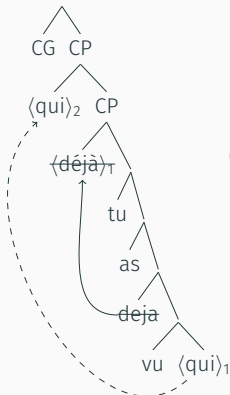
(Qui) tu as **déjà** vu (qui)?
(Who) you have DÉJÀ see (who)?

‘Who have you already seen?’

- This is unlike German *noch mal*.

¹⁴Here ‘...’ means unacceptable under the RMP but okay under another reading TBD.

Step 1: Overt movement to Spec-CP

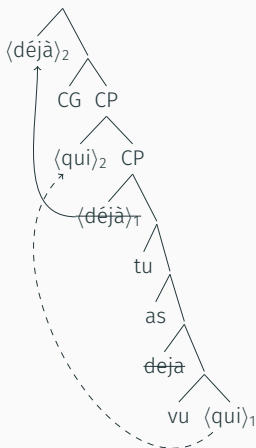


- This movement step is also supported by the **absence of intervention effects** between *déjà* and negation:¹⁵

- (19) a. Qui déjà tu n'as pas vu?
Who DÉJÀ you NEG-have NEG seen
'Who haven't you seen again?' (RMP ✓)
- b. Qui n'as-tu pas vu déjà?
Who NEG-have-you NEG seen DÉJÀ
'Who haven't you seen again' (RMP ✓)

¹⁵"Beck effects" (Beck, 1996, 2006), otherwise present in French between *wh in situ* and negation (Chang, 1997; Bošković, 2000). See Appendix for data.

Step 2: (C)overt movement above CG



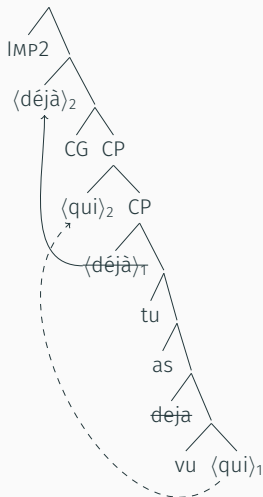
- Then, *déjà* moves overtly or covertly to a **position above CG**; see solid arrow.
- If this step is covert, *wh*-movement (dashed arrow) must be *overt*, granted *déjà* needs to attach to a host *wh*-word in Spec-CP.¹⁶
- This condition allows forms like *Déjà qui tu as vu?* and bans **Déjà tu as vu qui?*¹⁷
- In any case, we take that **only the highest copy of *déjà*** ($\langle \text{déjà} \rangle_2$) gets interpreted.

¹⁷Perhaps similarly to *diable*, 'the hell' (Obenauer, 1994)

¹⁷We'll later discuss another reading of *déjà* making this utterance ow-kay.

Interlude: trying out the SY17 recipe (simple sandwich)

- Suppose IMP2 were directly inserted at the top of the current tree.

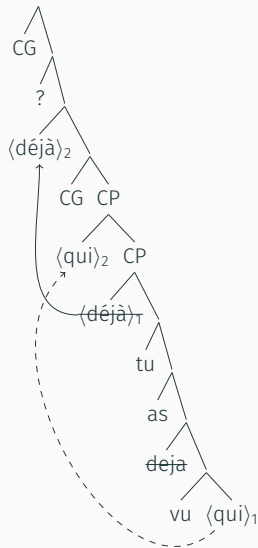


- **A weird meaning would arise:** that the speaker asks the addressee to make (18) true:

$$(18) \llbracket \text{d\'ej\`a CG Q} \rrbracket^{\text{spk}} = \\ \lambda e. \exists e' < e. \text{spk partakes in } e', \\ \text{and the full answer to Q is CG in } e'$$

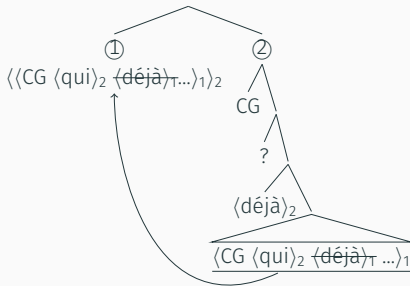
- Put differently, the addressee is expected to cause an event preceded by another event (i) involving the speaker and (ii) in which the answer is CG.
- **The IMP2 route is out;** would another Speech Act operator bring us closer to the desired meaning?

Step 3: merger of a second CG



- We assume that a **second CG operator gets merged** (the extra ?-operator below it just lifts the prejacent p into the question $\{p\}$).
- At this stage, the root meaning of the sentence is along the lines of: it is Common Ground whether it was at least once the case that it was Common Ground who you saw ($\simeq \text{CG}(\text{Asserted RMP})$).
- We are getting there, but we have to make sure we get the meaning of the question proper! IMP2 needs something to much on!

Step 4: movement of the lower CG[Q] constituent



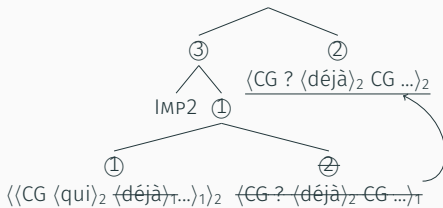
- The lower constituent CG[Q], subsequently **moves past the higher CG**, leaving behind an interpreted copy. The higher copy is what IMP2 will munch on.
- At this stage, node ② denotes the RMP.

- ① = λe . 1 iff the speaker partakes in e ,
and who the addressee saw is CG in e
- ② = λe . 1 iff the speaker partakes in e ,
and the fact that $\exists e' < e$ s.t. the speaker partakes in e' ,
and s.t. who the addressee saw is CG in e'
is CG in e

- But we are not done yet, as IMP2 needs to be merged to make the sentence a proper question...

Step 5: escaping IMP2 via extraposition

- To be fully presupposed at the matrix level the “RMP-node” ② needs to escape the scope of IMP2. This is done below.



- Now node ③ yields the at-issue contribution of the question, equal to $\text{IMP2}[\text{CG}[Q]]$, i.e. a request to the addressee to make the full answer to the question CG.

③ = it's an obligation that $\exists e$. the addressee causes e , the speaker partakes in e , and who the addressee saw is CG in e
 = **the question without *déjà***.

- Node ② (applied to the utterance event) yields the RMP.

Conclusion

- The French RMP was derived assuming *déjà* retains a unified meaning asserting what *again* presupposes, and undergoes several operations in the treetops forcing this assertion into the CG.
- In that sense, RMP *déjà* is similar to English *again* and German *noch mal*, but requires a heavier syntactic/LF machinery, which (roughly) emulates presupposition projection.
- Still, no further Speech Act operator beyond IMP2 and CG was eventually needed.
- If true, this constitutes extra evidence that Speech Acts are syntactically decomposed and that their various components are subject to usual movement operations.

Further discussions

More on word order

- *Déjà* is always **interpreted high** to yield the RMP, but can surface either after the *ex situ wh* (if its lower copy is realized), or sentence-finally (if its higher copy is realized).
- The former option forces the RMP, which makes sense assuming that as soon as *déjà* moves out from VP, it ends up LF-climbing to the treetops.
- Yet, **the latter option does not force the RMP**, even though *déjà* is out of VP. We think this is unproblematic, considering that *déjà can* in fact occur sentence-finally with its regular meaning in assertions; see e.g. (12). In such cases, *déjà* is probably extraposed, but still below Speech Act operators.

- (12) Ed a déclaré ses impôts **déjà**.
Ed has filed his taxes DÉJÀ.
‘Ed has filed his taxes **already/at least once** before.’

Special reading of high *déjà+wh in situ*

- We mentioned earlier that *déjà* was off in conjunction with *wh in situ* under the RMP reading:

(20) **Déjà** tu as vu qui? (RMP ✗)

- (20) can in fact receive a reading along the lines of *First off, who did you see?*¹⁸ This reading is not available for other positions of *déjà* and *qui* (the *wh*-item).
- This has a **Speech-Act-y flavor**: (20) means that the first Speech Act that the speaker wants to produce is an injunction to the addressee to make the answer to *who you saw* Common Ground.

¹⁸The question can be about somebody that the addressee did not see “first off”—in line with the intuition that *déjà* does not apply clause-internally here.

Special reading of high *déjà+wh in situ*

- (20) **Déjà** tu as vu qui?
DÉJÀ you have see who?
“First off, who did you see?”

- This corresponds to a reading of *déjà* that we overlooked so far!

- (21) Je vais **déjà** enlever mes chaussures.
I will **DÉJÀ** take-off my shoes.
‘I will first take out my shoes.’ ($\leadsto$ I have a list of things to do)

- (22) Peut-être que je vais **déjà** enlever mes chaussures.
Maybe that I will **DÉJÀ** take-off my shoes.’
‘Maybe I will first take off my shoes.’ ($\leadsto$ I have a list of things to do)

- Hypothesis: this variant of *déjà* can only move to Spec-CP if the upper Spec-CP is empty (i.e., no *wh*-movement).
- The presupposition of *first off-déjà* can project like *again*’s does in English; and its assertion undergoes the same CG-forcing mechanism as *ever-déjà*’s.

Why not the “direct” route?

- French does have a locution, *de/à nouveau*, akin to *again/noch mal*. Its standard projection signature is exemplified below.

(23) Lu n'a pas de/à nouveau fermé la porte.

Lu NEG-has NEG again closed the door.

‘Lu has not closed the door again. (she did before)’

(24) Peut-être que Lu de/à nouveau fermé la porte.

Maybe that Lu has again closed the door.

‘Maybe Lu has closed the door again. (she did before)’

(25) Est-ce que Lu de/à nouveau fermé la porte?

Is-it that Lu has again closed the door

‘Has Lu closed the door again? (she did before)’

- But this locution feels weird and forced in RMP settings.¹⁹ Why?

¹⁹If anything, the *à*-variant is slightly better.

Why not the “direct” route?

- The problem of French is a bit similar to Japanese—which “came up” with a special treetops particle to convey RMPs.
- But the French strategy—if on the right tracks—is arguably way more complicated than the Japanese strategy.
- To understand why French went this way, one may consider the fact that *déjà*, unlike *again*, *noch mal*, and *-ke*, comes with a variety of meanings: *already*, *ever*, and *first off*.
- Maybe this is where the advantage of *déjà* lies: **getting it to work at the treetops is not a walk in the park, but when done, one can derive a variety of Speech Act-level presuppositions.**²⁰

²⁰The question is then why we don’t get Speech Act-level *already* in French...

Future directions

Limiting the scope of the account

- The mechanism we proposed for the French RMP triggered by *déjà* **emulates backgrounding within the LF**.
- It's a complex but powerful machinery that may overgenerate with other particles carrying only asserted content.
- Identifying which operators/particles can climb up to the treetops in this way, and why they can do so is crucial to meaningfully limit the scope of this account.

Talking about other particles

- **Other particles** may lend themselves to a similar or simpler analysis.
- *wh+donc* questions, where *donc* normally indicates consequence (like English *then*) may presuppose the question was previously **left unresolved** or is very topical yet hard to address.
- *wh+au juste* ('*wh+exactly*') questions may presuppose that the question was **non-maximally resolved**.
- In English, *then* and *too* may also be of interest.

Other kinds of questions

- In this talk, I focused on *wh*-questions and the RMP.
- Regarding polar questions: if French indeed allows *overt* movement past CG, the question is **why the language does not allow the RMP in polar questions**, like Japanese does by means of the high particle *-kke*.
- I'll leave this for future work.

Thank you!

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The RMP with *now* (Lecavelier & Wimmer, 2025a, 2025b)

(26) a. Danish

Hvad hedder han **nu**?
what be.called.prs he **now**
'What is his name again?'

b. Finnish

Mikä sun nimi **nyt** oli?
what gen.2sg name **now** was
'What was your name again?'

c. Estonian

Mis su nimi **nüüd** oli(-gi)?
what your name **now** was-clit
'What was your name again?'

- LW25 propose the RMP arises as an implicature: the speaker asks **only now**, suggesting they did not need to ask before (because they knew the answer).

Beck effects in French (Beck, 2006)

- French allows wh-in-situ normally (27a), but not after an intervener like negation (27b).

(27) From Beck (2006), citing Pesetsky (2000) who cites Chang (1997) and Bošković (2000)

a. Ils ont rencontré qui?
 they have met who
 ‘Whom did they meet?’

b. # Il n’a pas rencontré qui?
 he NEG has NEG met who
 ‘Whom did he not meet?’ (only as echo question)

No projection with *ever-déjà*

- (28) C'est pas vrai que Jo a déjà vu Al.
It-is NEG true that Jo has DÉJÀ seen Al
'Jo has never seen Al.' (↗ Jo has seen Al before)
- (29) Peut-être que Jo a déjà vu Al.
Maybe that Jo has DÉJÀ seen Al
'Maybe Jo has seen Al before.' (↗ Jo has seen Al before)